priorities. The platinum jubilee celebrations of the Reserve Bank during 2009–10 provided an opportunity to get started on this. At a meeting with the top management of the bank where we were discussing the layout of the events and programme for the whole year, we agreed that we should embark on something that would have an enduring value extending beyond the platinum jubilee year. The outreach programme emerged out of this brainstorming. The idea was that all of us in the top management of the Reserve Bank would visit at least two villages each during the year, spending a good part of the day there, connecting with ordinary people and understanding their concerns, their problems and their way of life.

It was not as if we meticulously choreographed the outreach programme in all its detail before rolling it out. On the contrary, the programme got off the block with only a hazy structure and evolved over time, based on early experiences. The twin objectives of the programme too crystallized more clearly only down the line—first, to demystify the Reserve Bank which is to tell people what we do and how it makes a difference to their lives in a language and idiom that they can relate to; and second, to listen to them and understand their concerns so that decision-making in the Reserve Bank gets to acquire a human face.

A picture, they say, is worth a thousand words. Similarly, visiting a village, even if for half a day, and even if not seeing it in its everyday unrehearsed setting, is more valuable than studying dozens of books and reports on village life. It gives a perspective, a sense of reality, if also greater meaning to what the Reserve Bank does. Imagine, for example, that the issue before a deputy governor of the Reserve Bank is whether the area of operation of a banking correspondent should be increased from a radius of ten kilometres around the core village to fifteen kilometres. In the normal course, this issue would be decided by studying an analysis on paper of the pros and cons of doing so. Now imagine that the deputy governor actually sees a BC operate in a village and has an understanding of how a transaction is carried out on a handheld machine, the time it takes for each transaction, the volume and flow of work for the BC through a workday and the logistics involved in moving from one village to another. She would